Yet while policy was in confusion, and money was running out, on the ground the occupation was becoming daily entrenched, with the first and toughest of the memsahibs making the now dangerous journey through the Punjab to the Kabul cantonment. These first arrivals included Macnaghten's socially ambitious wife Frances, along with her cat and parakeet and five attendant ayahs. This at least provided some relief to the Eden sisters, who had been trying to avoid her company ever since her husband had left her with them in Simla. Then there was Florentia Sale, the indomitable Indian-born wife of 'Fighting Bob', who arrived in the summer of 1841 with a grand piano and her winsome youngest daughter, Alexandrina.

Not everyone was delighted by the arrival of the women. John Magrath, the grumpy cantonment surgeon, thought Ladies Sale and Macnaghten were 'both equally vulgar and equally scandalous' (without, sadly, giving more details), and was also dismissive of Lady Macnaghten's abysmal household skills. 'I dined at the Macnaghtens' some days ago,' he wrote in May 1841, 'and got a wretched dinner for my trouble of riding six miles for it.' Alexandrina Sale, he added, was 'ignorant and illiterate', though he conceded that she was at least said to be 'good tempered'.

Despite her alleged illiteracy, Alexandrina was soon being courted by half the officers in the cantonment. This Magrath put down to her 'being the only spinster here and . . . determined to get married . . . One thing in her favour is that she could not lose by comparison.'[31] Lady Sale disapproved of most of her daughter's suitors with their sweet nothings – 'Fair words butter no parsnips,' she was fond of observing – but she liked the handsome Lieutenant John Sturt, the engineer who had designed the indefensible barracks, and before long Sturt was widely judged to be well ahead of the pack, much to the envy of his single colleagues.

Lady Sale had had the foresight to bring enough seeds from her garden in Karnal to fill her Kabul borders with English blooms. 'I have cultivated flowers that are the admiration of the Afghan gentlemen,' she was writing before long. 'My sweet peas and geraniums are much admired and they were all eager to obtain the seed of the edible pea, which flourished well. In the kitchen garden the potatoes especially thrive.'[32]

It was not just the memsahibs who arrived at this time. Seeing Macnaghten reunited with his wife, Shuja now decided to bring his blind brother Shah